

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is a book review from a local newspaper:

Book review

What's the story about?

Paolo is a normal 13-year-old living in Italy in 1944, in an area controlled by German troops during World War II.

One night he is stopped by a group of men, pulled off his bicycle and dragged into the darkness. What happens next will change his life forever and put his family and friends in great danger. Saving his loved ones and surviving the war will take all of Paolo's courage.



Hero on a Bicycle
by Shirley Hughes
Walker Books

★★★★☆

Is it any good?

Hero is a very tense and vivid tale focusing on one boy and his family. Paolo is a lively and totally believable character. It is a thrilling and emotional novel about war, but also about courage and love in the face of terrible danger and hardship. The author was influenced to write this story by real-life accounts, stories of courage and suffering from actual people.

The scene-setting and character detail help to make the book excellent. The hero on a bicycle is an ordinary boy, but his story is certainly not ordinary. This is a novel well worth searching out on bookshop shelves overcrowded with books about wizards, vampires and magic. Strongly recommended as a thrilling and original read.

You have been asked to choose some English books for your school's Reading Club and you have just read this review. You may want to talk about:

- whether you would recommend *Hero on a Bicycle* for the Reading Club
- what other kinds of books you would choose
- the benefits and challenges of reading fiction
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. What do you like reading?
2. Do you think reading fiction is fun for young people?
3. Do you prefer reading fiction in English or Chinese?
4. Would you rather read stories about Hong Kong or another country?
5. Do you prefer reading a novel or watching the movie version?
6. How do you choose which books to read?
7. Do you find reading book reviews helpful?
8. Is it more important to read fiction or non-fiction?